

Obituary

JYOTI BASU | 1914-2010

The Last GENTLEMAN COMRADE

The iconic patriarch of Bengal communism and the master of power play did not hide his disillusionment with his own party

| By Goutam Ghose |

"On 14 September... we marched to the British Parliament when the British Prime Minister, Neville Chamberlain, came back from Germany and declared, 'I had an understanding with Hitler'. We said, you can't have an understanding with Hitler. So all of us, young students, went to the British Parliament to protest...."

My journey with Jyoti Basu took off way back in 1997. And it lasted eight long years, across campaigns and countries, to be relived on celluloid—*Jyoti Babur Songe* (Travelling with Jyoti Babu) in 2005. I had interviewed him extensively for that documentary and what remains etched on my mind is his incredible memory. He was 89 when he narrated the above story from his student days in London.

The idea of making a film on Basu began to take shape first when I travelled with him to Bangladesh in 1996. Typically, he refused. "Why a film on me," he laughed. I remember arguing with him: "Who else has witnessed history from such a vantage point and been in close quarters with the people who have changed modern India?" Finally, he agreed, but on condition that the project would have to wait until he bid goodbye to Writers' Building. "I can't speak freely when I am holding a position," was his rational take.

My primary motivation was to communicate, pro-

voke, inspire, as well as to document history. I remember the joy of posing questions to a man like him. But it was a challenge, too. I decided to go for a dialogue—a dialectical argument—where even if we did not agree, we would share some meanings and principles of inference. The questions ranged from personal (What's your greatest regret?) to global (What is your opinion about the collapse of the Soviet Union and the Iraq war?), national (Did you ever ask Indira Gandhi about her decision to impose the Emergency?), political (How do you explain the split within the Communist Party of India?) to local (What's the future of Bengal?).

Candid, precise, and without any intellectual pretensions, he answered my questions (I still remember how he asked me to leave the questions because he wanted to "do some homework"). He didn't object to sharp questions on his party, but I could feel a bit of anguish in him. As if he felt that there has been a huge change in the value system—in people, in politics and in his party—that he found difficult to relate to. He had joined politics to serve the people, not to gain power. "I had done the bar and had seen the world, but it was the terrible plight of the common people during the 1943 famine—as I and my co-workers volunteered and toured through villages, saw their hardship and went through our share—that made me who I am," he said, his eyes shining, ecstasy on his

